

Diplomacy **AFGHANISTAN**

Friday's attack was clearly focused on targeting Indians. The suicide attackers chose the early hours of a holiday when the chances of finding a large group of people was highest," says Shrinivas Rao Sohoni, senior adviser in the Office of the President of Afghanistan (cabinet secretariat).

Delhi had no doubt about the identity of the suicide attackers, hinting at the established nexus between Pakistan's ISI, the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) and the Haqqani faction of the Taliban. Official Afghanistan Police

Diplomatically, it represents India's biggest challenge in a region where US-led NATO forces have been battling the Taliban in a major new offensive and where a new great game is being played out by regional actors. Both India and Pakistan are trying to limit each others' stakes and influence in the land-locked country. India's strategic priority is to limit Pakistan's influence in Afghanistan while Islamabad has exactly the same objective vis-a-vis India. Afghanistan's strategic importance for India also lies in the fact that

in Afghanistan and it had arm-twisted the US and UK to keep India out of the Afghanistan donors' conference. The other side of the strategy is to use terror groups under its control to force India out of Afghanistan. "The terrorists targeted those Indians who were engaged in helping Afghan people and building partnership between the two countries," says Indian Ambassador Jayant Prasad. Pakistan knows that India's goodwill diplomacy in Afghanistan has eroded its own strategic aim of having control of the coun-

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PRESIDENT PRATIBHA PATIL PAYS FLORAL TRIBUTE TO THE VICTIMS OF THE KABUL BLAST

statements also blamed the LeT but for India, it is a serious setback to their efforts to establish a strategic presence in Afghanistan through a wide range of developmental projects. Afghanistan has been a priority area for India's foreign policy, and for its \$1.2-billion development diplomacy in Afghanistan which has earned considerable goodwill from the Afghan population. Hamid Karzai, the Afghan President, termed it a "terrorist attack against Indian citizens who are working to help rebuild Afghanistan".

instability in the country affects India's security. According to US Secretary of Defence and former CIA director Robert Gates, during the Taliban regime of 1996-2001, nearly 22 per cent of the terrorists operating in Jammu and Kashmir were either from Afghanistan or had been trained there.

For New Delhi, the stakes are considerably higher because of the nearly 4,000 Indians working on various Indian Government-funded projects in that country. Pakistan, on the other hand, seeks Afghanistan for 'strategic depth' and even by US estimates, uses the Taliban for strategic leverage inside Afghanistan. It is extremely uncomfortable with the Indian presence

try once the American and NATO forces leave. Moreover, a favourable government in Kabul also provides India access to Central Asia, which is important for Indian trade.

While the latest attack will not deter India from carrying on its development mission in Afghanistan, it will have to reassess its security options since it is obvious that Indians are more vulnerable than before. Only around a hundred personnel work at the Indian missions in Kabul, Mazar-e-Sharif, Herat, Kandahar and Jalalabad, while the rest work on the Indian projects spread all over the country and are sitting ducks for similar attacks. Rohit Verma, an Indian

KILLING FIELDS

- **February 26, 2010** A suicide attack in Kabul kills 10 Indians, including two Indian Army doctors. The Taliban claim responsibility but Pakistan hand suspected
- **October 9, 2009** Suicide bomber triggers explosives near the Indian Embassy in Kabul killing 12 people
- **July 7, 2008** Two senior Indian diplomats killed besides 41 others when suicide bombers rammed a vehicle into the Indian mission. The Afghan and US intelligence confirm the involvement of the ISI.